47TH ANNIVERSARY

THE BEST OF INDIA

DIPLOMATIC ACHIEVEMENTS





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Worldly Wise

Diplomacy is a process; real successes and failures sometimes manifest years after the event. What is hailed as a triumph today may be perceived as an optical illusion or even a debacle later. This listing also filters out the foreign policy achievements that are the accumulated outcome of technological progress (such as the Peaceful Nuclear Explosion of 1974) or military power (the battlefield victory in Bangladesh in 1971 or the Kargil war), although both categories of achievements had a significant diplomatic aspect. This is a listing of known and less well-known diplomatic achievements that showcase Indian diplomacy's ability to seize opportunities, think out of the box, and hold its nerve in the face of intense global pressure.

Ending War in the Korean Peninsula

1952-54

India played peace broker in ending the Korean conflict, the first major proxy conflict of the cold war. Initially rebuffed in the United Nations by the US and the Soviet Union, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru persisted. As a result, the final peace agreement of July 1953 owed much to the compromise suggested by India, which also played a major role in the supervision of the agreement. For a recently independent country, this was an audacious foray into the complex terrain of Cold War politics, and the experience served India well in the coming decades.

GETTY IMAGES



The Bandung Conference

Indonesia, 1955

The conference of 29 Afro-Asian nations in Bandung gave India a platform to move into a leadership position in what is now termed the 'Global South'. Although neither 'Bandung' nor the later Non-Aligned Movement came from a solely Indian initiative, they were substantially indebted to Indian diplomatic ideas and moves to consolidate a broad front of former colonies that functioned as a separate grouping in the bipolar world of the 1950s and 1960s.